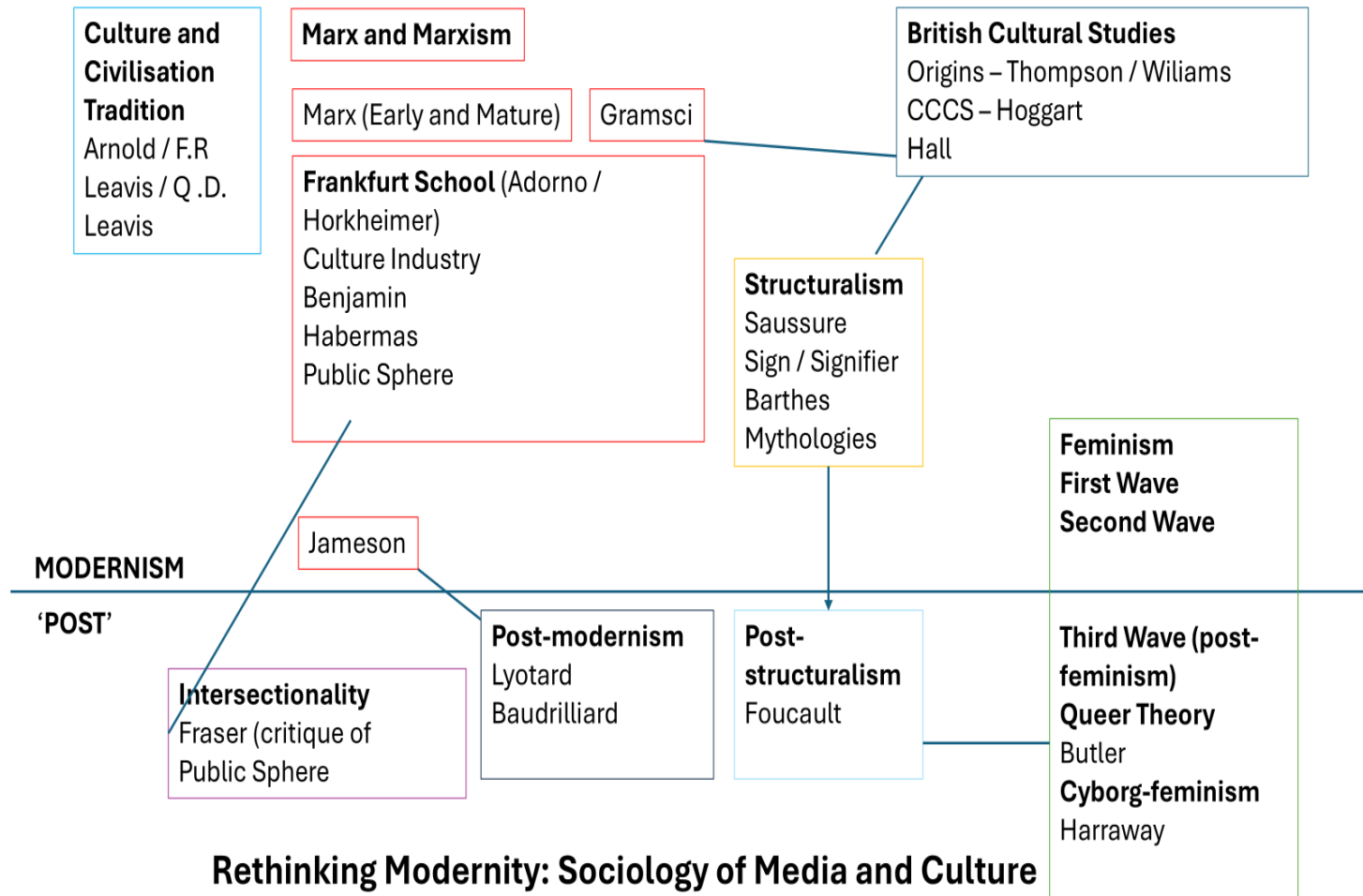
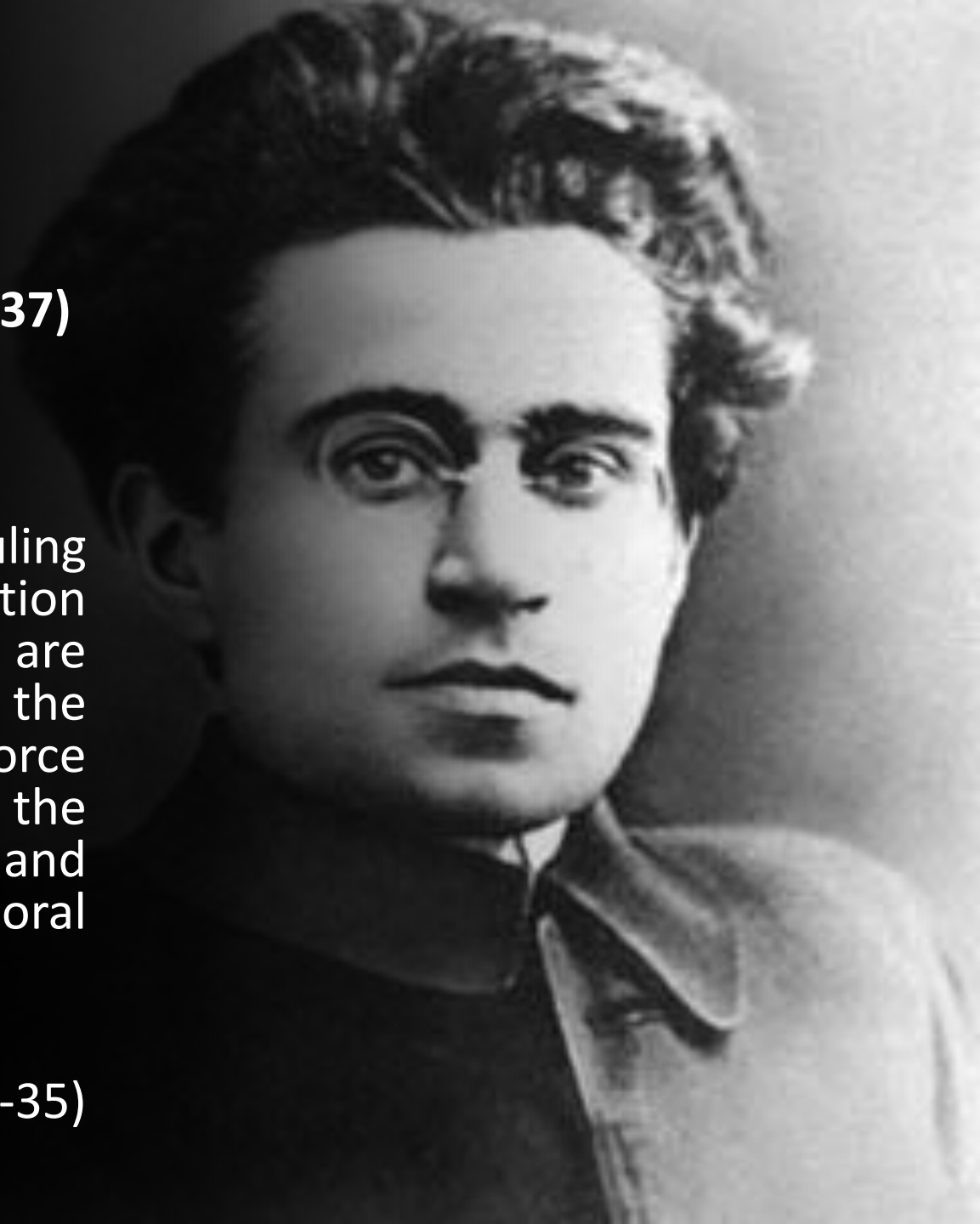




Gramsci's life

- Antonio Gramsci (1891–1937) was an Italian Marxist writing in the context of early 20th-century Europe, marked by mass politics, failed socialist revolutions in Western Europe, and the rise of fascism.
- His work emerged from a central problem in Marxism: why capitalist societies secured popular stability despite deep inequality.
- Gramsci wrote most of his theory in prison under Mussolini, producing the Prison Notebooks, which focus on culture, ideology, and power rather than economic determinism alone.

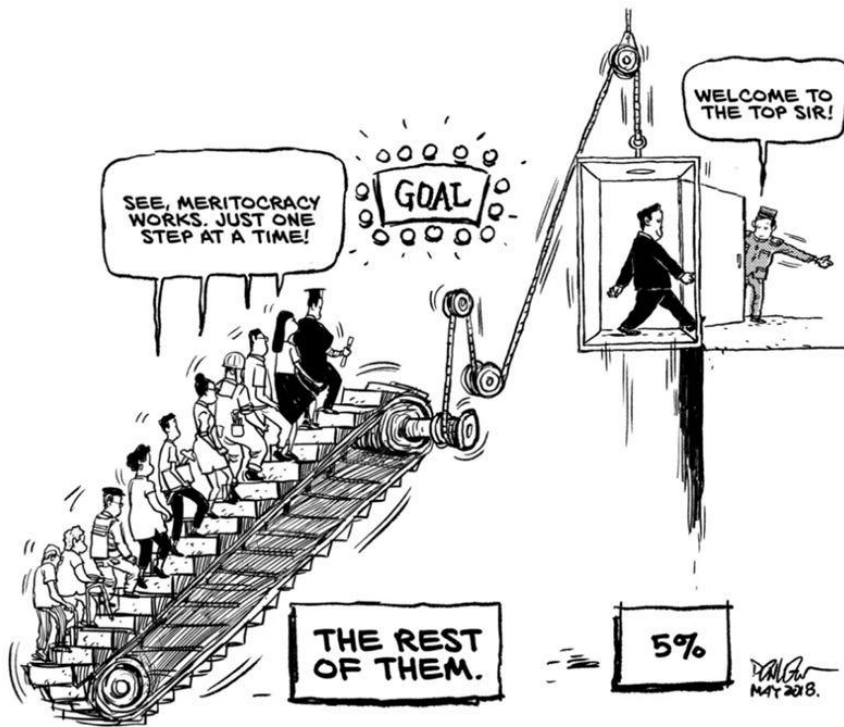
A black and white portrait of Antonio Gramsci, a young man with dark, wavy hair, looking slightly to the right with a serious expression. He is wearing a dark shirt and a light-colored jacket.

Antonio Gramsci (1891-1937)

The power of the ruling groups and the reproduction of the status quo are maintained less through the State's direct exercise of force than through the management of consent and through the exercise of moral and intellectual authority.

Prison Notebooks (1929-35)

Hegemony and civil society



Hegemony

Hegemony refers to the way a dominant social group maintains power primarily through consent rather than coercion.

For Gramsci, ruling groups succeed when their values, beliefs, and interests are accepted as common sense by society as a whole.

Hegemony is cultural and moral leadership, not just political control, and it must be continuously produced and renewed.

General Idea of Hegemony

...the supremacy of a social group manifests itself in two ways, as 'domination' and as 'intellectual and moral leadership'. A social group dominates antagonistic groups ...perhaps even by armed force, it leads kindred and allied groups. A social group can, and indeed must, exercise 'leadership' before winning government power (this indeed is one of the principal conditions for the winning of such power). It subsequently becomes dominant when it exercises power, but even if it holds it firmly in its grasp, it must continue to 'lead' as well.

(Gramsci, *Prison Notebooks*: 57-8)

Hegemony and Consent

- Hegemony involves the more or less active consent of large sections of the population
- Hegemony does not designate a particular ideology or even the ruling ideas in society but rather a process of management and administration
- Hegemony is not something imposed on society from above so much as generated from below
- The idea of the dominant ideology is one of exclusion (it excludes and suppress all opposition). Hegemony, on the other hand, involves processes of inclusion
- Hegemony = a process of negotiation or compromise on the part of the ruling elites
- Power = coercion + hegemony

Hegemony and the Media

- ❖ Are the Media the Principal Instruments of Hegemony?
- ❖ '...the class which has the means of material production at its disposal, has control at the same time over the means of material production'.
- ❖ The media mobilise and apply frameworks of thought -ideologies if you like- which are largely generated and maintained outside them.
- ❖ What Marx calls the 'means of mental production' are a far wider and more varied set of institutions and activities than those of the national media.
- ❖ The nuts and bolts of social knowledge are put together and adjusted by people in ordinary practical activities, or what Gramsci called 'civil society'.

Political society and civil society

- Gramsci distinguishes between political society and civil society.
 - Political society includes the state, law, police, courts, and military, and operates mainly through coercion.
 - Civil society includes media, education, religion, family, and culture, and operates through persuasion and consent.
- Media is located primarily in civil society and plays a key role in sustaining hegemony.

Hegemony and Civil Society

Civil society is where we live: its where we behave as members of families and of local communities, where we work and relax, where we engage in social celebrations like a Millennium street party or social protests.



Civil society is the key place where ideas and practical behaviours are directly knitted together.



Civil society is the social space which both distances us from and connects us to the State.

Hegemony as a Political Process of Social Management and Administration

- All the public institutions of civil society are engaged in developing and managing the part of world with which they're concerned.
- The social group who carry out these types of activities are organic intellectuals.
- Unlike the dominant ideology thesis, the concept of hegemony describes a complex process of codification and management, not a system of ideas.
- Hegemony, on the other hand, treats ideas as the codification of practical experience.

Counter-hegemony and organic intellectuals



CLASS WAR



**WE HAVE FOUND NEW
HOMES FOR THE RICH**

Common Sense and Good Sense

- Common sense is the everyday, taken-for-granted set of beliefs through which people understand the world. It is historically produced, often contradictory, and shaped by dominant groups.
- Good sense refers to the critical and reflective elements within common sense that can challenge dominant ideas. Hegemonic struggle involves shaping common sense while suppressing or marginalising good sense.

Intellectuals and Cultural Power

- Gramsci defines intellectuals broadly as those who organise ideas and meaning in society.
- Traditional intellectuals see themselves as neutral or independent.
- Organic intellectuals emerge from specific social groups and articulate their interests.
- Media professionals (journalists, editors, cultural producers) can function as organic intellectuals by shaping narratives, values, and social norms.

Media as a Site of Hegemonic Struggle

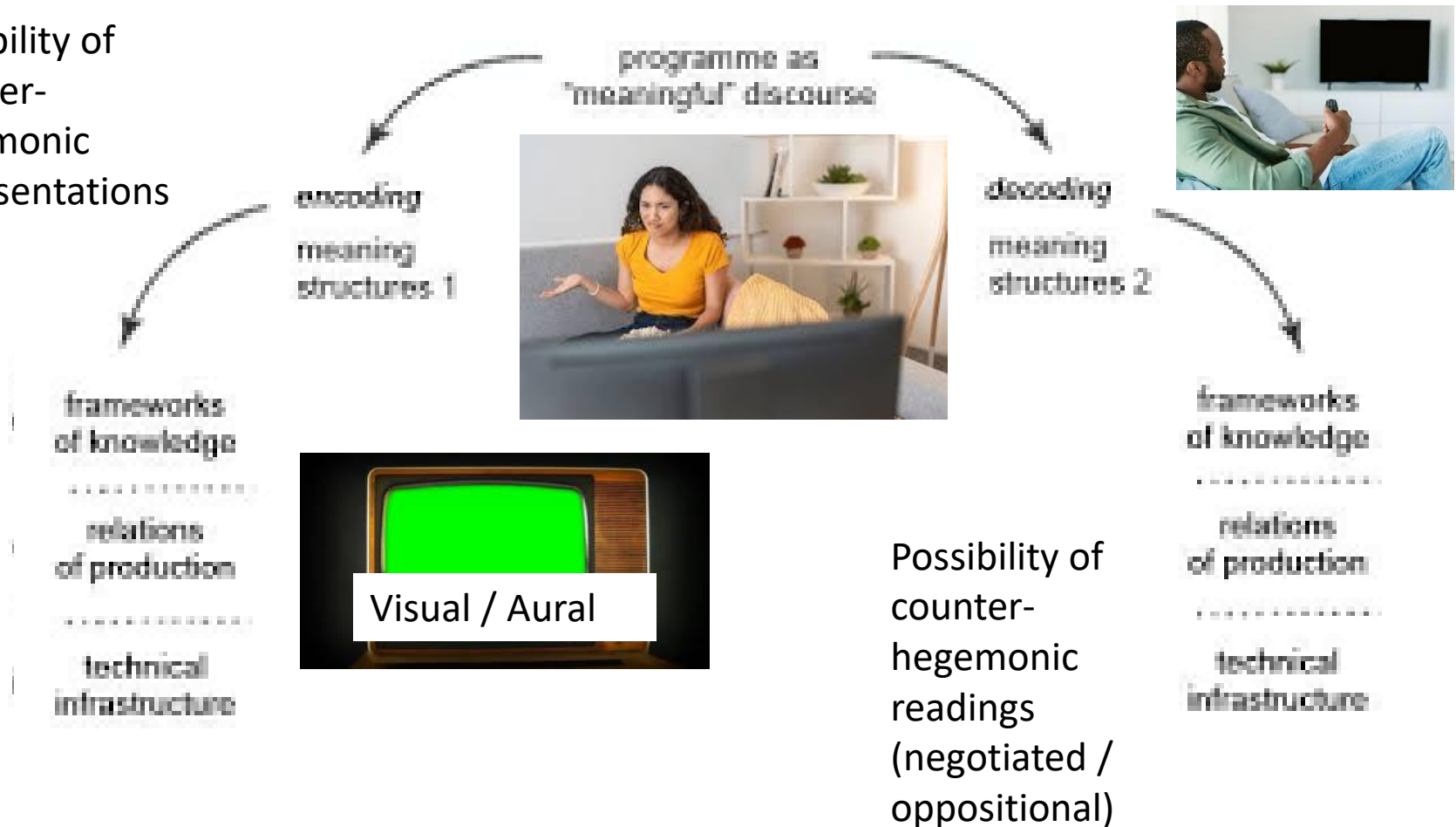
- From a Gramscian perspective, media does not simply transmit information; it constructs reality through framing, representation, and repetition.
- Media normalises particular explanations of social issues (e.g. individual responsibility over structural causes), helping to stabilise hegemonic common sense while managing dissent within acceptable limits.

War of Position

- A war of position refers to a long-term struggle within civil society to reshape culture, values, and common sense.
- Unlike a war of manoeuvre (direct revolutionary confrontation), Gramsci argues that social change in advanced capitalist societies requires sustained cultural and ideological struggle, particularly through media, education, and popular culture.

Hall 'Encoding and Decoding in the Television Discourse' (1973) – hegemony and counter-hegemony

Possibility of counter-hegemonic representations



Hall and Gramsci

- Hall extends Gramsci's concept of hegemony to race and other categorisations.
- In 'The Whites of Their Eyes: Racist Ideologies and the Media' (1981) he employs the term 'grammar of race' to show how racial (white / colonial) hegemony is encoded in media representations – can be decoded in ambivalent and contradictory ways.
- In 'Policing the crisis' shows how capitalist hegemony displaces the crisis onto a moral panic ('mugging') but also how counter-hegemonic Black resistance / protest might operate.

Examples of counter hegemony

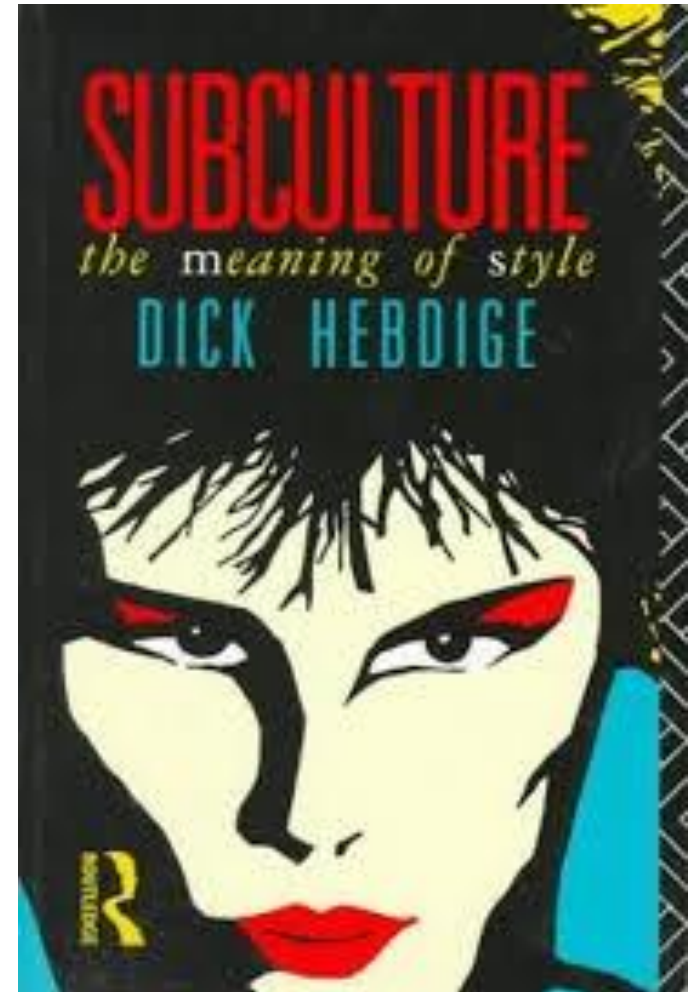


Media, hegemony and counter-hegemony

- Stuart Hall incorporated Gramscian ideas to show how hegemony was encoded in media-messages but also how counter-hegemony could inform oppositional readings in decoding, and how sub-cultures could act counter-hegemonically
- The study of media in order to assess the impact of ideology was largely abandoned in the 1980s. This was a legacy of the Frankfurt School but also post-modernism.
- Scholars such as John Fiske argued that audiences were so empowered that ideology and effect had become irrelevant.
- For Fiske the role of media consumption in the production of personal and group identities was most important.
- Similarly other scholar's have disregarded the encoding component of Hall's model, focusing only on the reception of media content.

Subcultures as counter-hegemonic

- Subculture is a minority culture within a primary culture. This minority culture goes against the accepted norms and habits of the majority society.
- Often youth subcultures are closely associated with certain media.
- According to Hebdige, subculture is consumers acting against the expectation of passivity.
- They resist cooption into society through ritual and style. Subcultures can be **counter-hegemonic**
- Subcultures make use of media objects as part of this construction.
- However, this may result in the generation of new commodities and industries, eventually coopting the subculture into the majority capitalist culture.
- Market research firms engage in trend spotting, selling their insights to the market and accelerating this process.



Fandom as counter-hegemonic

- Fandom is similar to subculture, though much more focussed around one particular media
- Members of fandoms set themselves apart from 'casual' consumers through their devotion and knowledge of their media interest.
- Tulloch describes them as a 'powerless elite'. They are distinguished from other fans by their knowledge of, and engagement with, the media they consume, but often powerless to influence its content.
- Jenkins describes fandoms as 'textual poachers'. They claim back power by appropriating the characters and worlds of media and create their own interpretations, storylines and artefacts. **This can act to resist hegemonic interpretations.**
- They trespass on the grounds of the powerful content producers.
- Fandoms are indicative of many changes in cultural consumption that have come hand in hand with New Media.



Contemporary Relevance and Critique

- Gramsci remains relevant for analysing digital media, platforms, and culture wars, where power operates through visibility, algorithms, and moral framing rather than force.
- Critiques argue that Gramscian analysis can overemphasise culture at the expense of material structures or treat hegemony as too totalising. Nonetheless, his framework remains central for understanding media, consent, and cultural power.



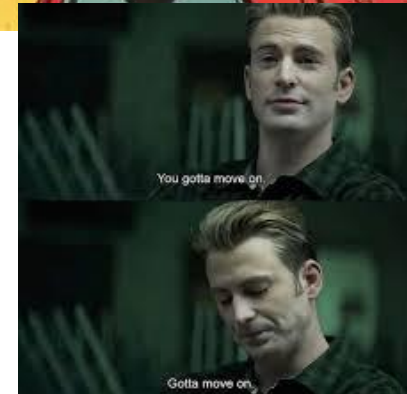
Superheroes: hegemony (see Engstrom and Beliveau: Gramsci and Media Literacy)

Superheroes, from Superman onwards, have been used to portray ideas about freedom, race, and masculinity.

<https://m.youtube.com/watch?v=Q2l4bz1FT8U&pp=ygUcc3VwZXJtYW4gMTk1MHMgZnVsbCBlcGlzb2Rlcw%3D%3D>

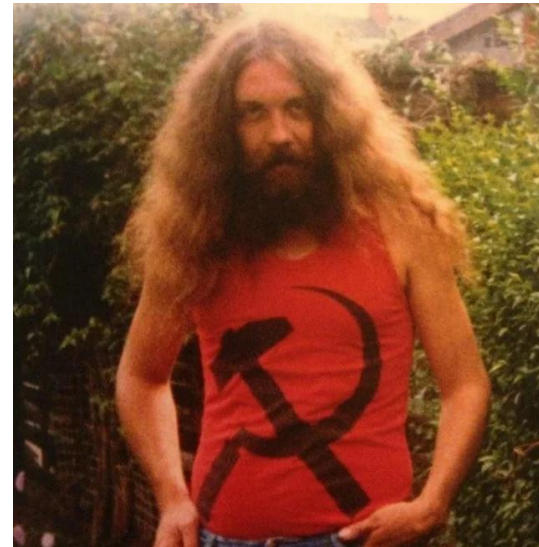
More recently there have been attempts to portray superheroes as embodying more liberal / new masculine values (in the MCU, for example Captain America runs a support group). Hegemony in practice...

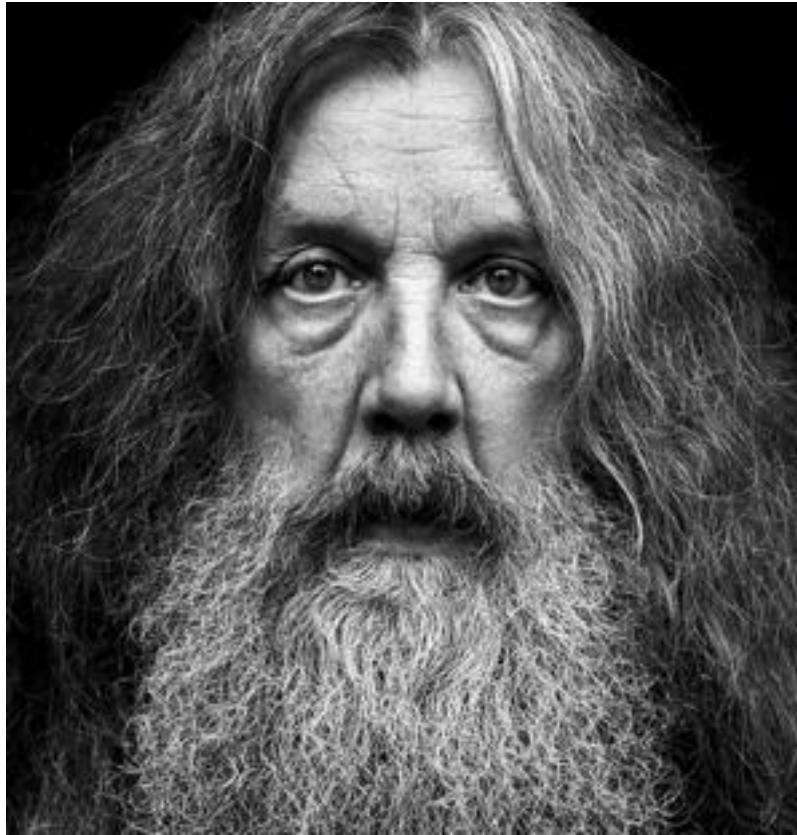
<https://m.youtube.com/watch?v=ODEKCA8pAHs&pp=ygUdY2FwdGFpbiBhbWVyaWNhIHh1cHBvcnQgZ3JvdXA%3D>



Superheroes:counter-hegemony (see Engstrom and Beliveau:
Gramsci and Media Literacy)

- ‘Organic intellectuals’
from working class
backgrounds with radical
politics such as Alan
Moore (Watchmen) and
Garth Ennis (The Boys)
have reinvented the
superhero genre to
explore themes of
corruption, ego
cowardice,
commodification,
fascism, racism and
sexism.





"The Superman myth is a story about greatness and wish fulfillment. All superhero legends are based on this concept. Superman is the sun that all others revolve around. The story is a representation of an alien being who comes to Earth and just so happens to blend in among humans while using his unique abilities, not to rise above us, but to help us. He cannot be a god because gods are dictators who set rules for others to follow. Superman sets rules for himself and uses those rules for our benefit. The myth was perfected from the 1950's through roughly the 1970's under the pencil of a severe talent, Curt Swan. If America has a legend comparable to the ageless myths of antiquity, there's is Superman."
- Alan Moore, 1999, being interviewed about his Image Comics *Supreme* work.

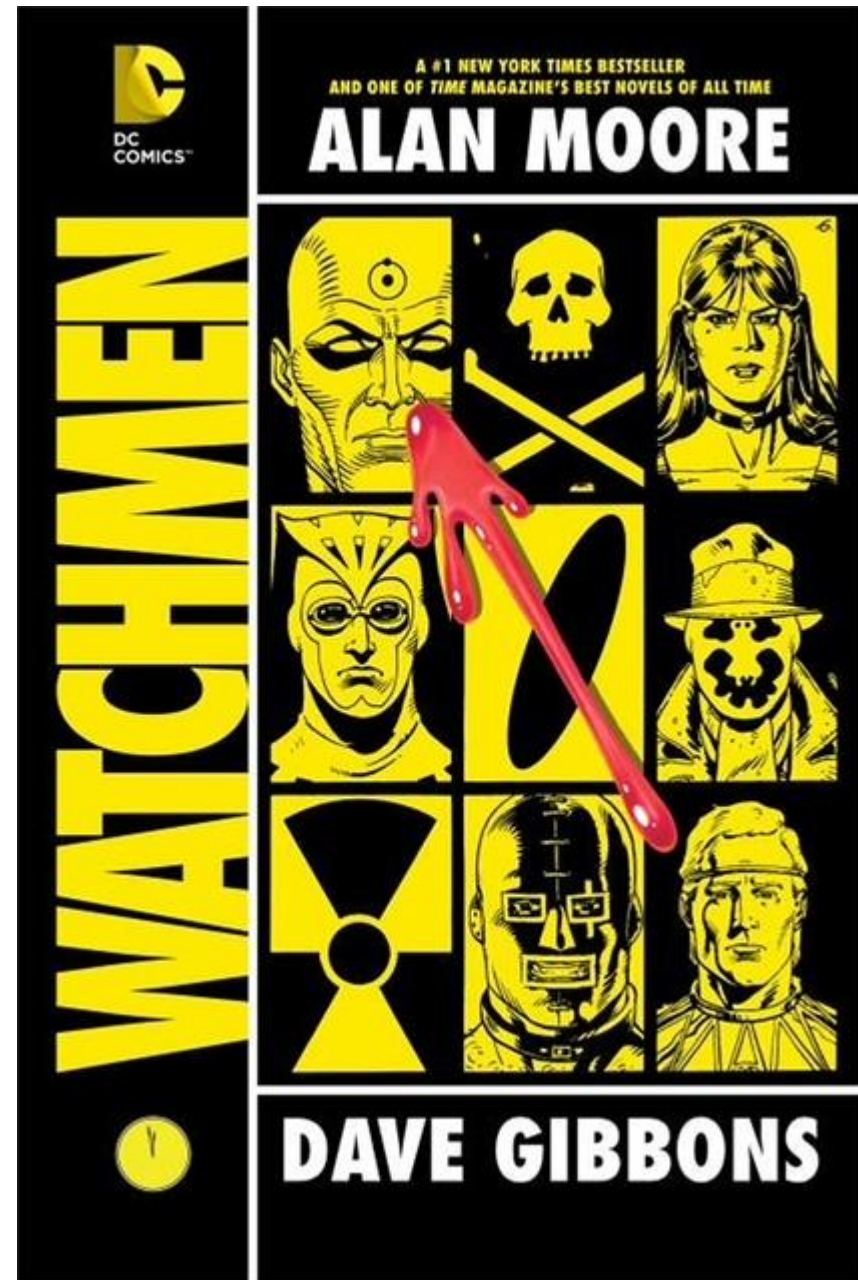


If you look at Marvel Comics,
there are very few Marvel
characters I would like to write.

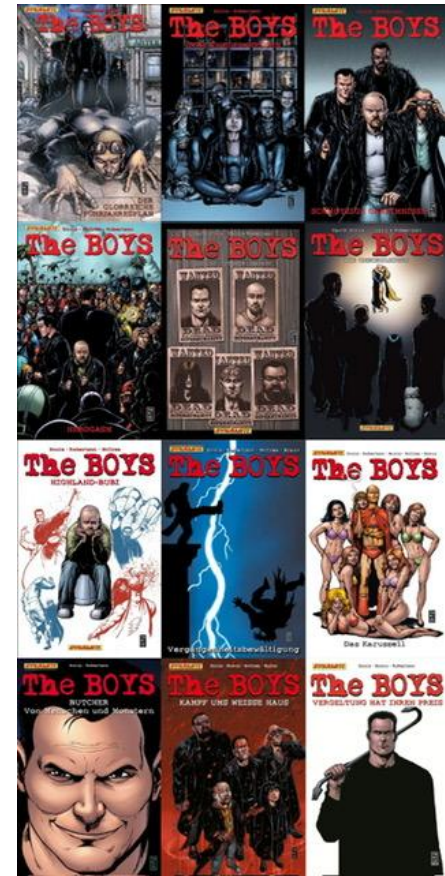
Garth Ennis

 quote fancy

Alan Moore



Garth Ennis



Film / television adaptations

- Film and television adaptations have introduced audiences to these counter-hegemonic representations and even subverted the original comics to allow for counter-hegemony. For example, in The Boys (TV) subverting the myth of heroism: <https://m.youtube.com/watch?v=HK0qxKsMPzQ&pp=ygUTSG9tZWxhbmRlciBhaXJwbGFuZQ%3D%3D> or in Watchmen (TV)'s main character is a Black, female superhero (Sister Night) who fights fascists. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=prnhmxs0pjw>



Essential reading

Tony Bennett

Introduction: popular culture and 'the turn
to Gramsci'

Politically speaking, both the structuralist and culturalist paradigms subscribe to a rather similar conception of the structure and organisation of the cultural and ideological spheres viewed in relation to the antagonistic economic and political relationships between social classes. Although importantly different in other respects, both paradigms regard the sphere of cultural and ideological practices as being governed by a dominant ideology, essentially and monolithically bourgeois in its characteristics, which, albeit with varying degrees of success, is imposed from without, as an alien force, on the subordinate classes. Viewed from this perspective, the main differences between the two perspectives are largely nominal

(In structuralism, 'popular culture', 'mass culture' and 'dominant ideology' are usually equated through a series of sliding definitions. In consequence, the chief political task assigned to the study of popular culture is that of reading through popular cultural forms and practices to reveal the obfuscating mechanisms of the dominant ideology at work within them, thus arming the reader against the occurrence of similar mechanisms in related practices. In culturalism, by contrast, popular culture, in being equated with the 'autochthonous' culture of subordinate classes, is explicitly distinguished from and opposed to dominant ideology in the form of mass culture. Where this conception prevails, analysis is dominated by a positive political hermeneutic: that of, having found the people's authentic voice, interpreting its meaning and amplifying its cultural volume. To be sure, the consequences of these contrasting orientations are by no means negligible. In spite of these, however, the two approaches share a conception of the cultural and ideological field as being divided between two opposing cultural and ideological camps — bourgeois and working class — locked in a zero-sum game in which one side gains only at the expense of the other and in which the ultimate objective is the liquidation of one by the other so that the victor might then stand in the place of the vanquished.

1

For Gramsci too, of course, cultural and ideological practices are to be understood and assessed in terms of their functioning within the antagonistic relations between the bourgeoisie and the working class as the two fundamental classes of capitalist society. Indeed, Gramsci's insistence that these antagonistic class relations form the ultimately determining horizon within which cultural and ideological analysis must be located constitutes the outer limit to the programme of theoretical revision he inaugurated in relation to classical Marxist theories of ideology.⁸ Where Gramsci departed from the earlier Marxist tradition was in arguing that the cultural and ideological relations between ruling and subordinate classes in capitalist societies consist less in the *domination* of the latter by the former than in the struggle for *hegemony* — that is, for moral, cultural, intellectual and, thereby, political leadership over the whole of society — between the ruling class and, as the principal subordinate class, the working class.

P. 27
As a consequence of its accommodating elements of opposing class cultures, 'bourgeois culture' ceases to be purely or entirely bourgeois. It becomes, instead, a mobile combination of cultural and ideological elements derived from different class locations which are, but only provisionally and for the duration of a specific historical conjuncture, affiliated to bourgeois values, interests and objectives. By the same token, of course, the members of subordinate classes never encounter or are oppressed by a dominant ideology in some pure or class essentialist form; bourgeois ideology is encountered only in the compromised forms it must take in order to provide some accommodation for opposing class values. As Robert Gray remarks, if the Gramscian concept of hegemony refers to the processes through which the ruling class seeks to negotiate opposing class cultures onto a cultural and ideological terrain which wins for it a position of leadership, it is also true that what is thereby consented to is a *negotiated version* of ruling class culture and ideology:

In sum, then, the 'turn to Gramsci' has been influential in both disputing the assumption that cultural forms can be assigned an essential class-belongingness and contesting a simply 'bourgeois versus working class' conception of the organisation of the cultural and ideological relationships. These reorientations have resulted in two decisive shifts of political emphasis within the study of popular culture. First, they have produced a perspective, within Marxism, from which it is possible to analyse popular culture without adopting a position that is either opposed to it or uncritically for it. The forms of political assessment of cultural practices which the theory of hegemony calls for are much more conjunctural and pliable than that. A cultural practice does not carry its politics with it, as if written upon its brow for ever and a day; rather, its political functioning depends on the network of social and ideological relations in which it is inscribed as a consequence of the ways in which, in a particular conjuncture, it is articulated to other practices. In brief, in suggesting that the political and ideological articulations of cultural practices are *movable* — that a practice which is articulated to bourgeois values today may be disconnected from those values and connected to socialist ones tomorrow — the theory of hegemony opens up the field of popular culture as one of enormous political possibilities. It is thus, for example, that in many recent debates, the call has been made that nationalism, and the forms in which it is constructed and celebrated, should be given a socialist articulation rather than be dismissed as essentially and irredeemably bourgeois.¹¹

Equally important, the Gramscian critique of class essentialist conceptions of culture and ideology and the associated principles of class reductionism enables due account to be taken of the relative separation of different regions of cultural struggle (class, race, gender) as well as of the complex and changing ways in which these may be overlapped on to one another in different historical circumstances. Apart from being an important advance on classical Marxism, this has also served as an important check on the Foucauldian tendency to view power and the struggle against it as equally diffuse and unrelated. Most important, though, it has offered a framework within which the relations between the cultural politics of socialist movements and those of, say, feminist or national liberation struggles can be productively debated without their respective specifications threatening either to engulf or be engulfed by the others.